MAIE5103 · ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE ETHICS

AI in Politics

Data, platforms, democratic rights, and governance

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Lecture 10 · Week 10

From political influence to public participation

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A sequence for locating AI systems inside political information and civic institutions.

01

Frame
rights and political agency

02

Identify
political AI tasks

03

Trace
data and platform power

04

Test
claims against evidence

05

Govern
systems for participation

The unit of analysis is a sociotechnical system—not a model, message, or election result in isolation.

Political AI is more than election content

Different tasks shape different decisions, exposures, and accountability questions.

Predictive

Estimate a likelihood, score, or risk.

Ethical focus
validity · bias · contestability

Recommender

Rank, select, or prioritize what is encountered.

Ethical focus
exposure · transparency · agency

Generative

Create or transform text, image, audio, or video.

Ethical focus
provenance · attribution · trust

Aggregation

Combine inputs to surface patterns or group views.

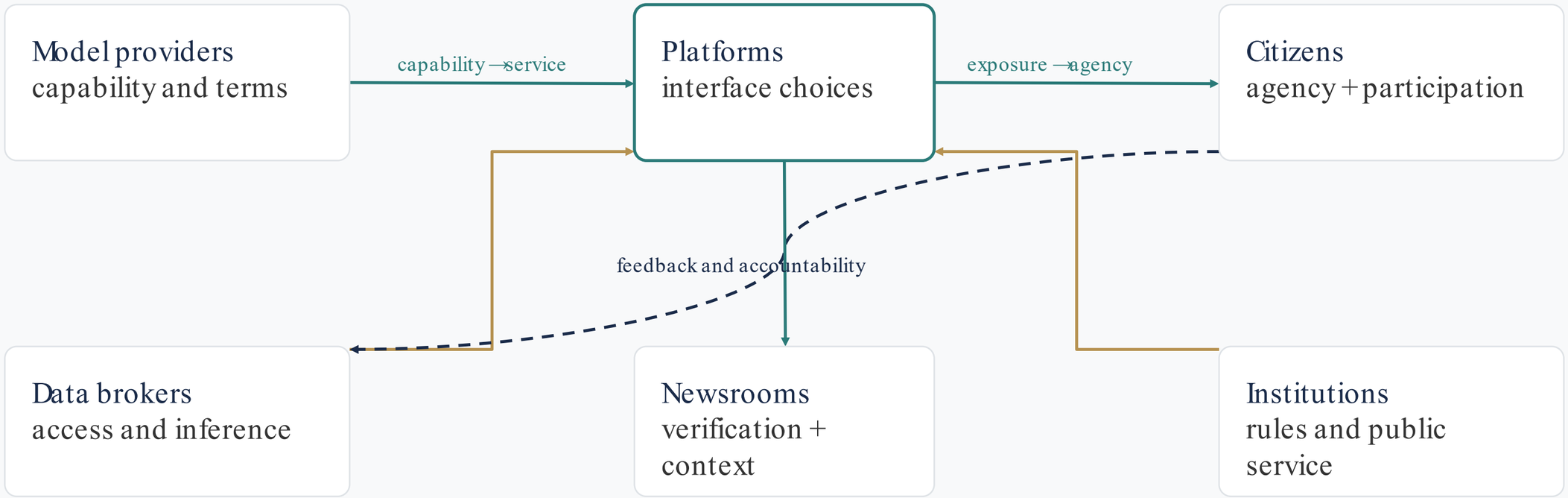
Ethical focus
representation · inclusion · governance

Task labels clarify the mechanism before we make claims about political impact.

Conceptual framing: International IDEA, Artificial Intelligence for Electoral Management (2024).

The political AI ecosystem

Political consequences arise through connections among providers, intermediaries, institutions, and publics.



Value and accountability travel through interfaces; neither is guaranteed by the model alone.

Conceptual framing: OECD, Reinforcing Democracy Initiative (2024).

Democratic rights are system requirements

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The Universal Declaration of Human Rights frames political agency, not merely information accuracy.

UDHR Article 12

Privacy

System requirement
Limit unjustified intrusion and uncontrolled reuse of personal data.

UDHR Article 19

Expression and information

System requirement
Support access to, and exchange of, information and opinion.

UDHR Article 21

Participation and equal access

System requirement
Protect meaningful participation in public affairs and elections.

Arights-respecting system preserves agency across data use, information access, and participation.

Primary source: United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights (Articles 12, 19, 21).

Business incentives shape political information

Platform design is shaped by organizational objectives as well as public values and legal duties.



The ethical question is not whether incentives exist; it is how governance keeps them compatible with public agency.

Context: OECD, Reinforcing Democracy Initiative (2024).

Data access is not meaningful consent

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A permission moment does not settle the social consequences of a data-driven service.

01
Purpose
Collection goals

02
Secondary use
Purpose changes

03
Access
Receiving parties

04
Delivery
Actual use

05
Outcomes
Effects on people

Meaningful consent requires an intelligible account across the full chain, not only a checked box at collection.

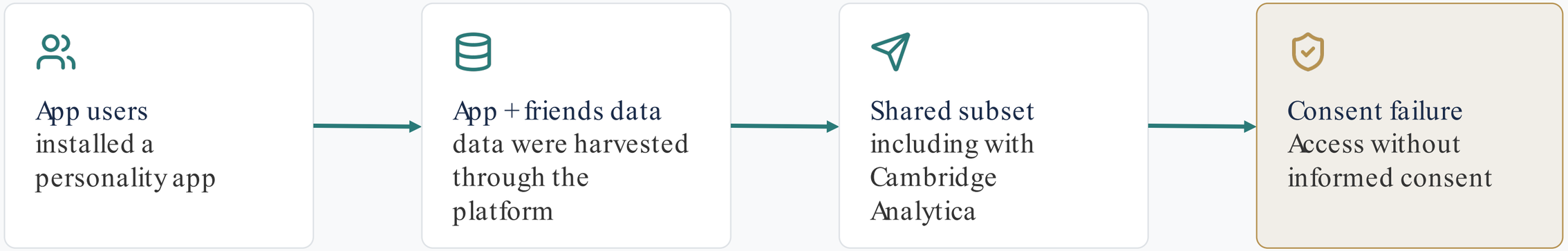
Case context: UK ICO, Investigation into data analytics in political campaigns (2018)

Cambridge Analytica: a documented data governance failure

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Up to 87 million
Facebook app / friends data period: 2007–2014

ICO scope: Facebook users, not voters or changed votes



The documented harm is unauthorized collection and disclosure; the record does not establish an election outcome.

Sources: UK ICO investigation (2018) · FTC Cambridge Analytica order (2019).

The remedy was institutional, not just technical

FTC action against Facebook · July 2019

$5bn settlement and a 20-year privacy governance program.
It was not a Cambridge Analytica fine or a per-person harm valuation.

Control	Institutional location	Why it matters
Privacy committee	Board oversight	Elevates privacy accountability beyond a product team.
Compliance officers	Named senior roles	Assigns responsibility for a privacy program.
Independent assessor	External review	Tests whether controls operate as required.
App and platform controls	Product governance	Constrains third-party access and data practices.

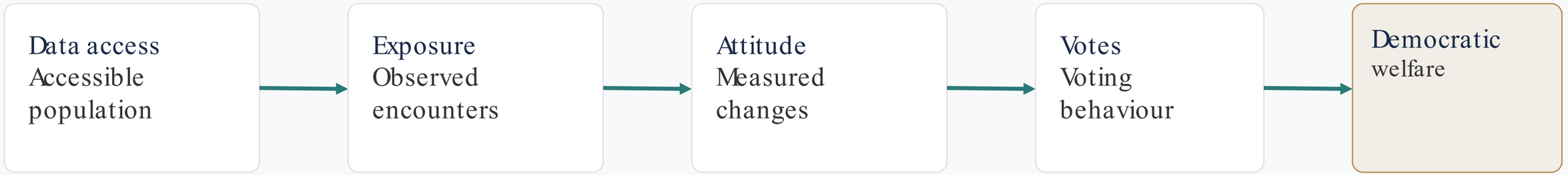
Institutional controls specify who is accountable, what is reviewed, and how a platform's access rules can change.

Primary source: FTC, Facebook settlement and privacy restrictions (2019)

Profiling capability does not prove electoral impact

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Acausal claim must carry evidence across distinct endpoints; a data capability alone is an early link.



Evidence discipline

No verified causal proof establishes that Cambridge Analytica changed an election outcome.

Sources: UK ICO investigation (2018) · FTC Cambridge Analytica order (2019).

New Hampshire 2024: a synthetic-voice trust incident

The case concerns the integrity of trust signals, not a replay of the deceptive audio.

Incident record

21 Jan 2024 calls initiated

AI-cloned voice and caller-ID spoofing before the 23 Jan primary.

9,581 initiated calls

Not unique listeners, believers, or changed votes.

Two separate trust signals

Voice
familiarity signal

Caller ID
identity signal

Caller-ID attestation can be authorized without authenticating the message content.

FCC final order adopted 26 Sep 2024, released 30 Sep 2024; the record does not establish voting or turnout effects.

Primary sources: FCC final order FCC-24-104 (2024); FCC declaratory ruling FCC-24-17 (2024).

A communications violation, not a blanket voice AI ban

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The FCC's 2024 action combined distinct authorities and distinct actors.

21 January 2024
AI-cloned voice and caller-ID spoofing calls were initiated before the New Hampshire primary.

8 February 2024
FCC clarified AI-generated human voices fall within TCPA artificial or prerecorded-voice rules.

30 September 2024
$6m monetary forfeiture against Steve Kramer for unlawful caller-ID spoofing.

Legal basis
Proven violation: caller-ID spoofing with intent to defraud, cause harm, or wrongfully obtain value.

Consent rules
The TCPA clarification applies its consent and exemption structure; it does not make every AI voice unlawful.

Separate provider action
Lingo's August consent decree was a separate provider matter. A forfeiture order is not evidence that a fine was collected.

Sources: FCC 24-104 final order · FCC 24-17 TCPA clarification · Lingo consent decree

Slovakia 2023: a late incident, bounded inference

Evidence records a fabricated or manipulated audio incident; it does not establish electoral causation.

Observed timeline

28 September
Fabricated or manipulated audio surfaced late in the campaign.

30 September
Parliamentary vote followed two days later.

Incident record
Telegram and multiple platforms carried the item. No deduplicated audience measure is available.

Provenance limit
Author, production method, and precise origin were not established in the public record.

Impact
Voter effects unknown.

Interpretation: Election results are aggregate outcomes, not a counterfactual for one late clip. The responsible claim is about observed manipulation and an evidence gap.

Sources: International Press Institute incident report; HKS Misinformation Review analysis

Synthetic, false, and deceptive are different axes

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Production, factual truth, authenticity, and intent are distinct dimensions of an evidence-based response.

Term	Production	Factual truth	Authenticity	Intent
Synthetic	AI-generated or altered.	May be true or false.	Not an unaltered event recording.	May be disclosed, creative, educational, or deceptive.
False	AI or non-AI production.	Claim is inaccurate.	Authentic image, false caption.	Error and intent need separate evidence.
Deceptive	Any production method.	True facts, omissions, or falsehoods.	May appear authentic or synthetic.	Designed to mislead an audience.
Authentic	May include AI assistance.	Does not establish every claim.	History and source can be assessed.	Context sets the interpretation.

Analytic rule: a label answers only one axis; it cannot substitute for an evidence judgment.

Conceptual distinctions informed by C2PA 2.4 Explainer and WIRED / WITNESS expert perspective

The liar’s dividend damages genuine evidence

Definition: ambiguity about synthetic media can be used to dismiss genuine evidence as fabricated.

Genuine evidence
A consequential recording or image enters public debate.

→

Calibrated skepticism
Check source, history, context, and independent corroboration.
Keep uncertainty explicit while evidence is assessed.

→

Accountable judgment
The judgment states what is supported, what remains uncertain, and what evidence would change the conclusion.

Failure mode: blanket distrust makes authentic documentation easier to deny and weakens accountability.

Source framing: WIRED, “Prepare for the Deepfake Era of Web Video” (2019) — historical expert perspective, not an election-effect estimate.

Trust beyond a technical checkmark

Verification is a social practice: provenance, analysis, context, and communication work together.



Original WITNESS response network illustration; related teaching visual, not a film still.

WIRED / WITNESS, 2019

Sam Gregory's perspective connects authentication limits with the public's need for context.

A detection output is not a complete judgment about truth, harm, or response.

Original WIRED film (2019)

Scope: a qualitative expert perspective from 2019, not a 2026 detector benchmark or proof of electoral effects.

Sources: Source video—WIRED / Sam Gregory, 2019; WITNESS Deepfakes Rapid Response Force

Provenance validates a history, not the truth

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A Content Credential can support an asset history; factual claims still need corroboration and judgment.

1 · Credential integrity
Well-formed manifest, asset binding, tamper evidence, and trusted signer.
This is a history and integrity check.

2 · Context corroboration
Location, time, caption, source account, and independent reporting provide corroborating evidence.
This is an evidence comparison.

3 · Evidence-based judgment
A proportionate assessment identifies supported claims and remaining uncertainty.
This is accountable interpretation.

Important: absence of a credential does not make content false; adoption is optional and uneven.

Source: C2PA 2.4 Explainer — credential validation complements fact-checking, media literacy, and digital forensics.

Five disrupted operations: what was observed

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OpenAI's May 2024 vendor report describes detected cases and service intervention, not global prevalence.

Detected
Five operations were detected during the preceding three months. Detection is not a census.

→

Intervened
Accounts were disrupted on the reporting service. That does not erase activity elsewhere.

→

Observed use
Reported uses were mostly human-operated content, translation, and research support.

→

Breakout
None exceeded Category 2 on the report's rubric.

Unmeasured outcomes: No independently established audience or voter impact; observed report assessments do not establish causal proof of attitude change, voting behavior, or electoral outcomes.

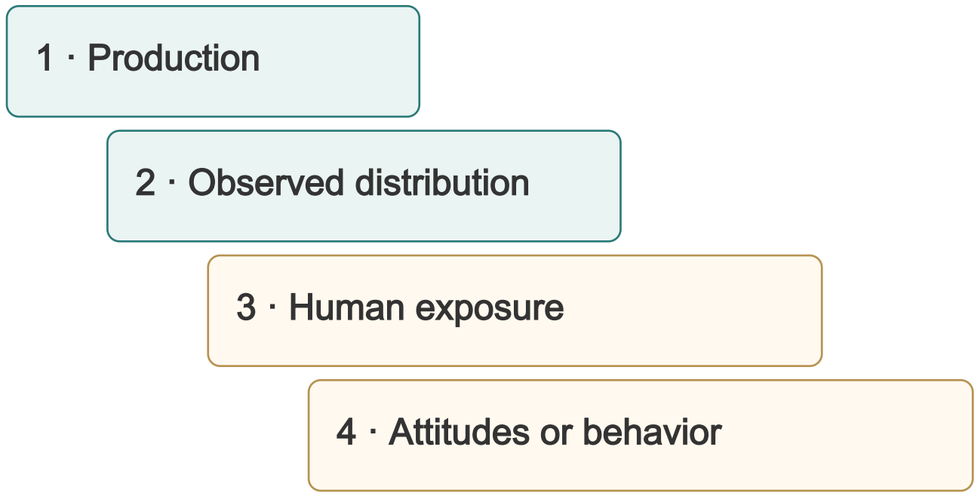
Sources: OpenAI threat-intelligence report, May 2024; Breakout Scale

Content production, audience reach, and political effect

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Each step up the ladder asks for stronger evidence and supports a narrower claim.

Evidence ladder



Interpretive discipline

- The Breakout Scale is a rubric, not an interval scale.
- Vendor observation supports bounded operational claims.
- Manufactured replies do not equal authentic engagement.
- Voting outcomes require a causal design and evidence absent here.

Sources: OpenAI threat intelligence report, May 2024; Brookings, Breakout Scale

Verification is a human–technical network

Different roles address access, reliability, and interpretation; a detector alone cannot close the loop.



Original WITNESS response-network illustration. It depicts a verification ecosystem, not a detector-accuracy result.

Journalists: source access and reporting context

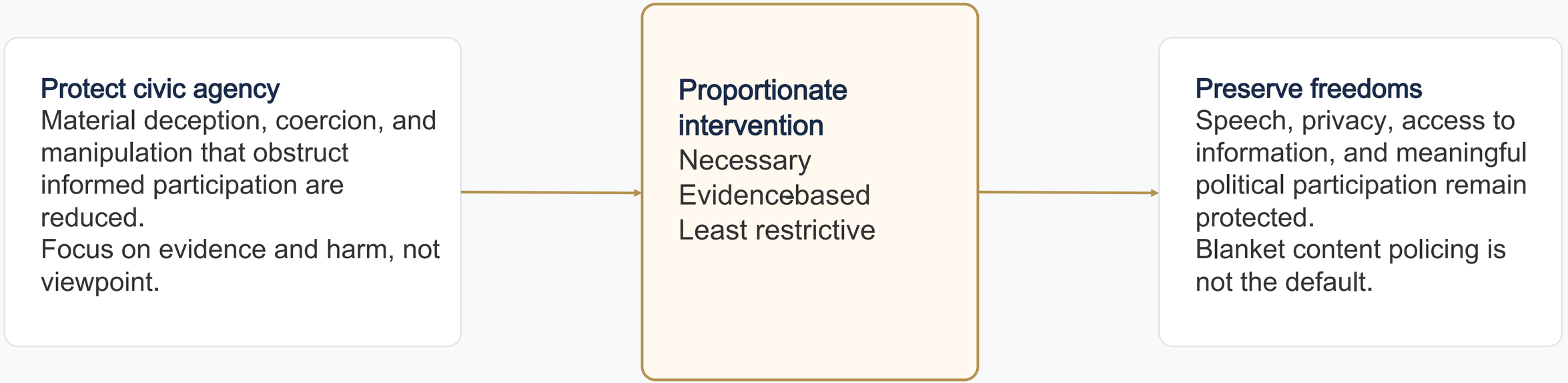
WITNESS coordination: referral and interpretation

Forensic experts: reliability analysis and limits

Source: WITNESS, Deepfakes Rapid Response Force. Roles paraphrase its access, detection reliability, and interpretation challenges.

Information integrity must preserve civic freedoms

Legitimate responses protect political agency while respecting expression, privacy, and due process.



Safeguards: clear legal basis · independent review · reasoned decisions · meaningful appeal

Sources: Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Arts. 12, 19, 21; International IDEA (2024)

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Break

10 minutes

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A controlled test of conversational persuasion

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Randomized debate conditions

Opponent: human or GPT-4

Consented data absent or basic participant data

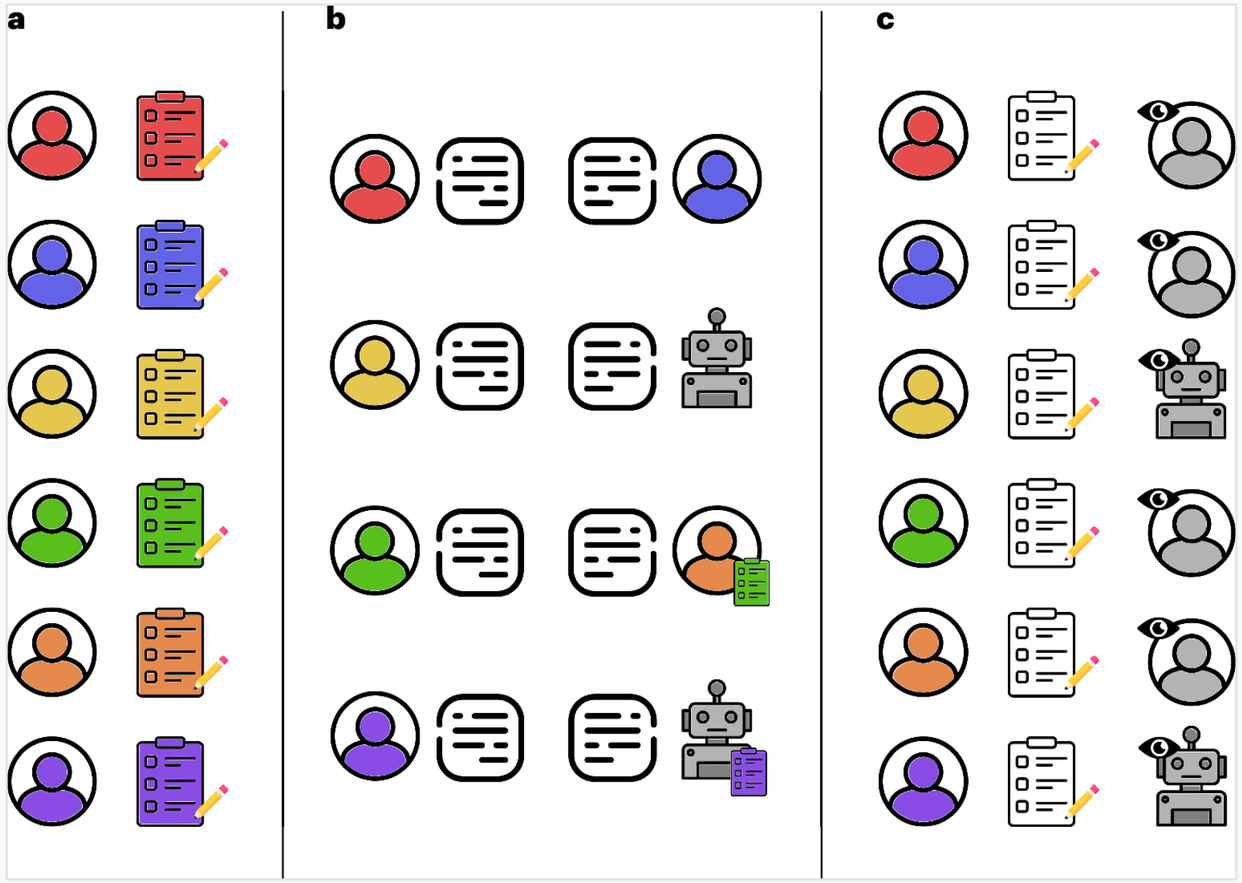
Prior opinion strength: low, medium or high

Outcome: pre/post 1–5 self-reported agreement toward the assigned opposing side

N=900 US adult Prolific participants

600 written debates

Immediate attitudes, not votes

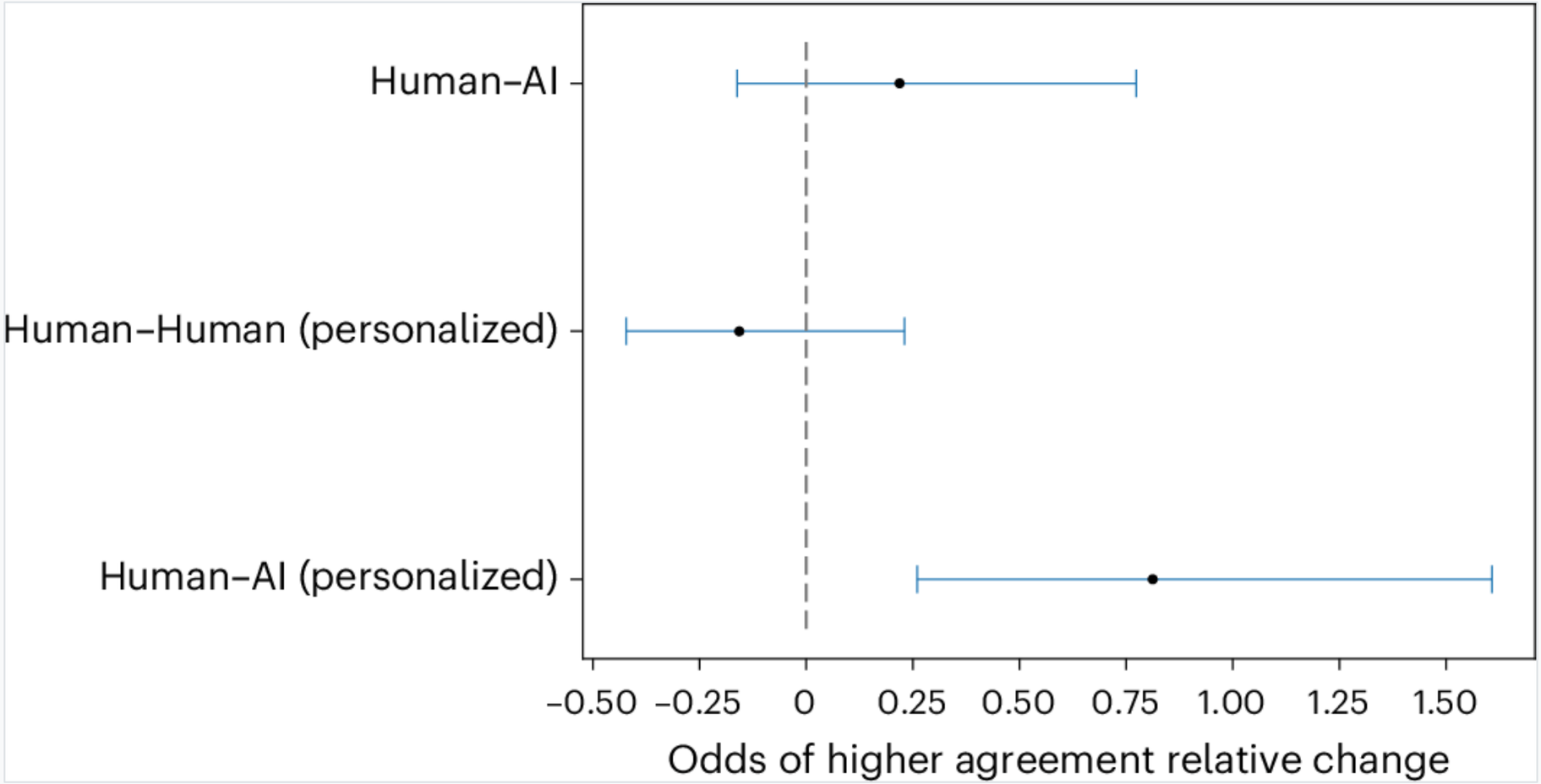


Original study Figure 1, retained unaltered. Our annotations at left state the design and scope.

Source: Salvi et al. (2025), Nature Human Behaviour, Fig. 1 (CC BY 4.0).

Comparator and statistical uncertainty

- Personalized GPT-4 versus the human–human baseline; model n=750 analyzed debates



Source: Salvi et al. (2025), Nature Human Behaviour, Fig. 2. +81.2% odds; 95% CI +26.0% to +160.7%; immediate agreement, not voters.

The 2026 correction changes a key claim

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Corrected direct comparison

+48.7% odds

95% CI −2.9% to +127.6%

P=.0678, rounded to .07

Not conventionally significant

Personalized GPT-4 vs nonpersonalized GPT-4

Two claims must stay separate

Human baseline comparison

Personalized GPT-4 exceeded the human human baseline in the original figure.

Incremental personalization

The corrected direct contrast does not establish a personalization advantage over generic GPT 4.

Source: Author correction, 3 September 2026; original study: Salvi et al. (2025).

Evidence about influence has distinct endpoints

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Arandomized immediate attitude measure identifies a different endpoint from each subsequent claim.

Randomized lab attitude

Immediate self-reported agreement

Durability

Persistence beyond the session

Political behaviour

Voting and participation are separate outcomes

Democratic welfare

Rights, knowledge, inclusion and legitimacy

Across every link

External validity

Informed consent

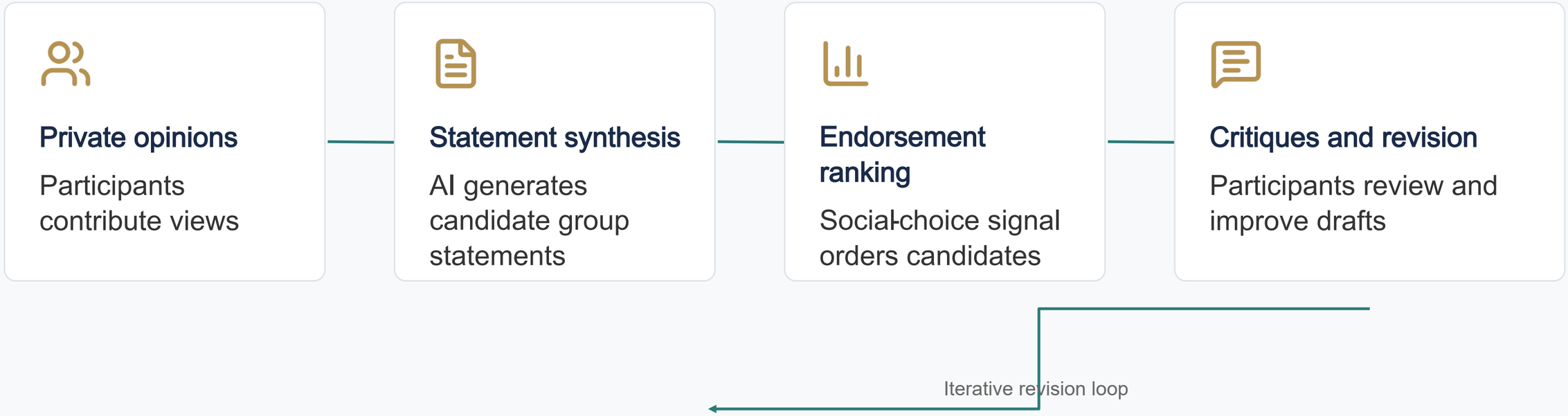
Appropriate population and context

Attitude effects do not establish voting effects or democratic benefits without additional evidence.

Evidence framing applied to Salvi et al. (2025); ethics scope informed by UDHR Articles 12, 19 and 21.

Habermas Machine: AI-assisted mediation

A system for drafting and revising group statements, not an automated policy vote.



Human judgment appears at input, endorsement and critique; the model supports mediation.

Source: Tessler et al. (2024), Science. Narrative editable mechanism, based on the reported workflow.

Preference for a statement is a bounded result

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Paired source-blind statement preference



Comparator: financially incentivized **non-professional** human writers or mediators. This is not a claim about all professional civic facilitators.

A source-blind preference measure is not a vote, policy quality, adoption or durability measure.

Scope and limits

N=5,734 total participants across experiments

Not the direct comparison sample

1,919 repeated comparison records are clustered, not independent trials

No standalone CI is shown here

Source: Tessler et al. (2024), Science. Native bar reproduces the reported 56% versus 44% comparison.

Approval and minority protection are not equivalent

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Meaning of an approval signal

A statement was preferred or endorsed under specified conditions.

text and embeddings →

Requirements for democratic legitimacy

Interests and stakes
Distribution of consequences

Power and authority
Decision and contestation rights

Dissent and protection
Minority interests and safeguards

Representation
Inclusion of missing voices

Inclusion in a text model does not, by itself, guarantee equal power or protected interests.

Source: Tessler et al. (2024); legitimacy framing aligned with UDHR participation and equality principles.

vTaiwan connects a tool to institutions

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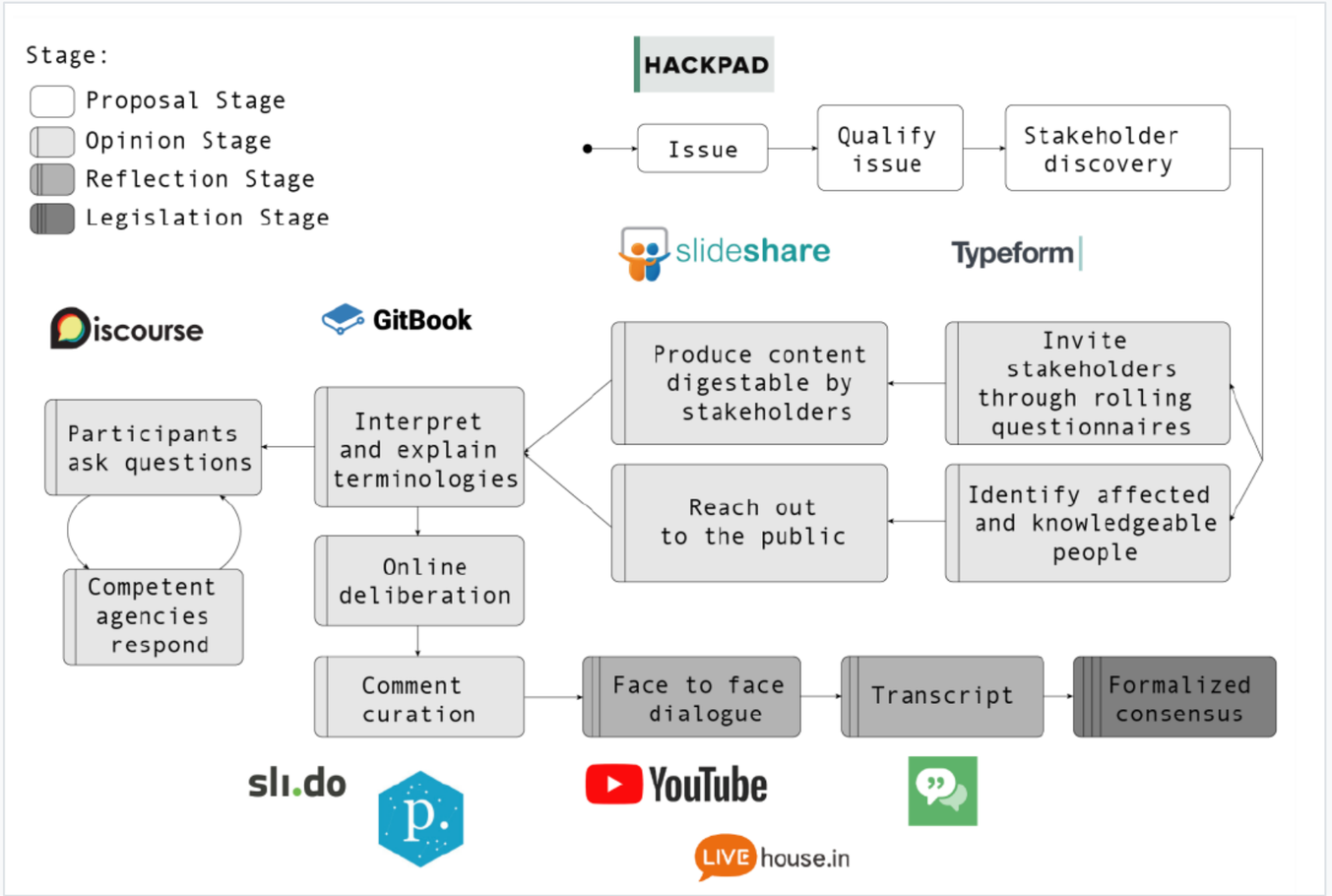
2015 Uber consultation

Online opinion mapping and reflection were linked to stakeholder dialogue.

The process then entered an institutional pathway toward formalization.

An official regulatory response followed on **25 Oct 2016**

Workflow evidence, not proof that Polis caused every rule or law.



Original Figure 2: vTaiwan workflow across proposal, opinion, reflection and legislation stages.

Sources: Small et al. (2021), Fig; Taiwan MOJ, 25 Oct 2016 version

What the Polis map actually represents

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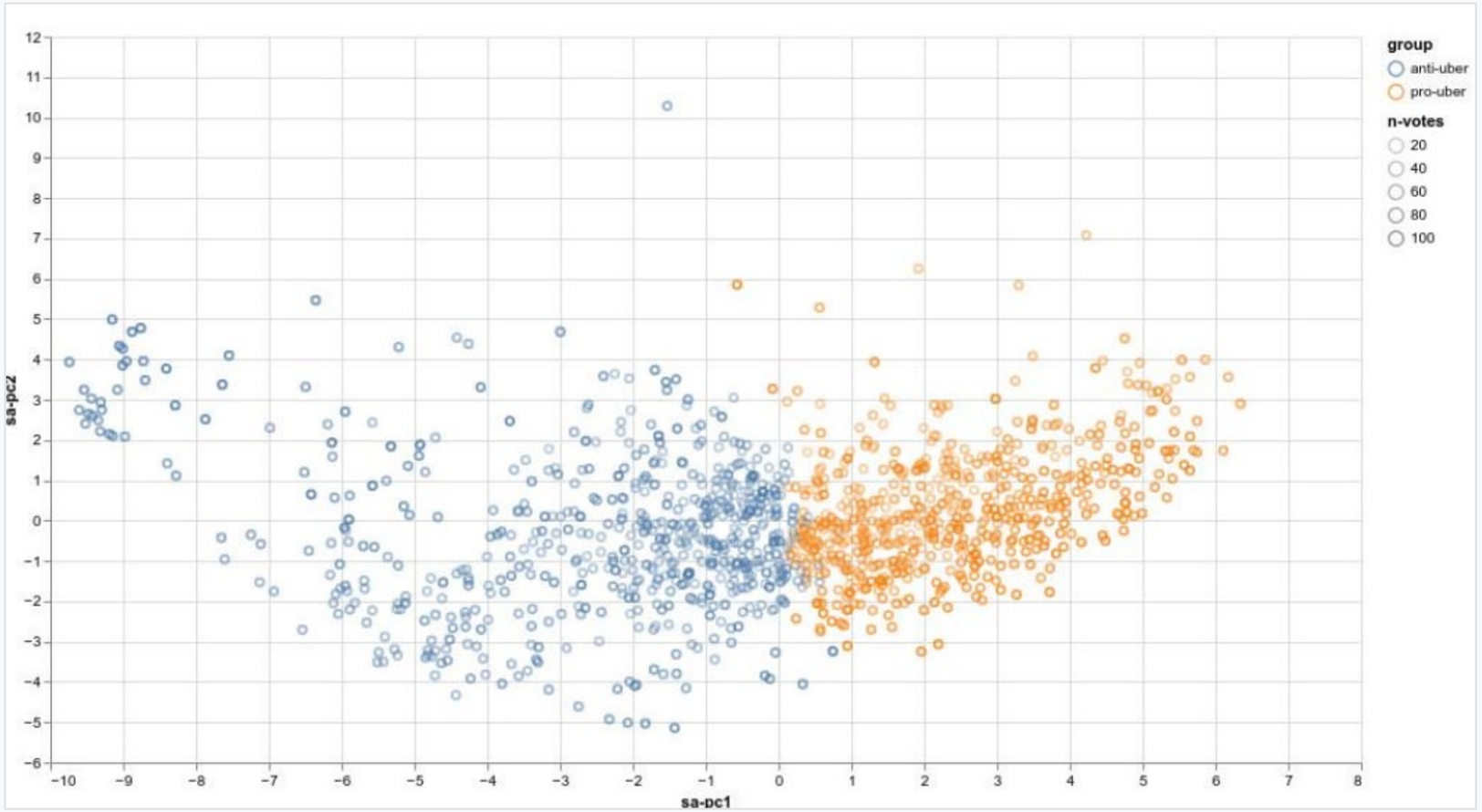


Figure 3, Uber 2015

1,238 filtered participants

98 moderated comments

PC1: **22%** variance

PC2: **6.2%** variance

Mean-imputed unseen responses; moderation and exclusions shape the analytic map.

Self-selected nonprobability sample; clusters are not vote share.

2015 system: no NLP or GenAI.

Source: Small et al. (2021), Fig. 3. Original map retained unaltered; analytic details from the paper.

Civic technology in practice

Original BBC Click film —Can Taiwan Reboot Democracy? (29 October 2019)

Human-written inputs, statistical mapping, and institutional response remain distinct.

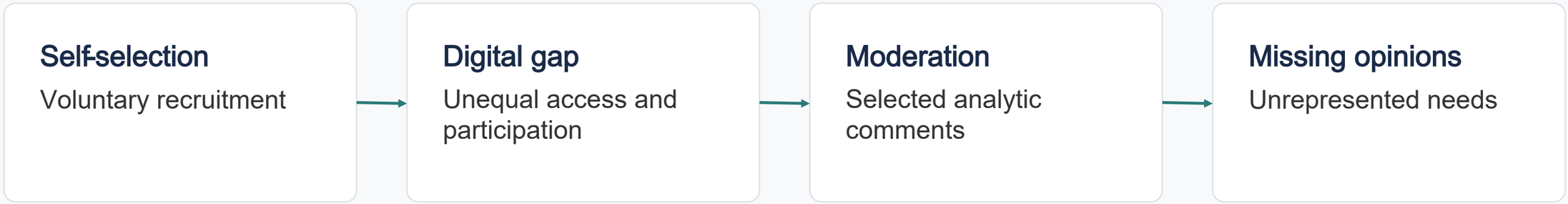


Source reporting illustrates a tool and institutional setting; it is not independent evidence of impact, representativeness or causation.

Sources: BBC Click (2019), original film; method context from Small et al. (2021).

Participation is not representativeness

Avisible consultation signal passes through several filters before it can be interpreted as a public view.



A consultation map can inform a process. It is not a representative population estimate or a binding referendum.

Recruitment, access, moderation and analytic choices determine what becomes visible.

Source: Small et al. (2021) Consultation and map interpretation limits are conceptual, not population estimates.

AI in electoral administration: support versus authority

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Human authority is the safeguard. AI may support administrative work; it should not decide eligibility, ballots, or result relevant judgments.

Potential support, subject to testing, audit, and human review

Authority remains human

Election stage	Supportive uses	Human authority / rights boundary
Pre-electoral	Procedure information, accessible formats, logistics anticipation	No autonomous eligibility or registration decision
Electoral	Helpdesk triage, translation support, incident routing	No ballot or decisional algorithm
Post-electoral	Reconciliation support, public information, auditable records	Human review of result-relevant judgments

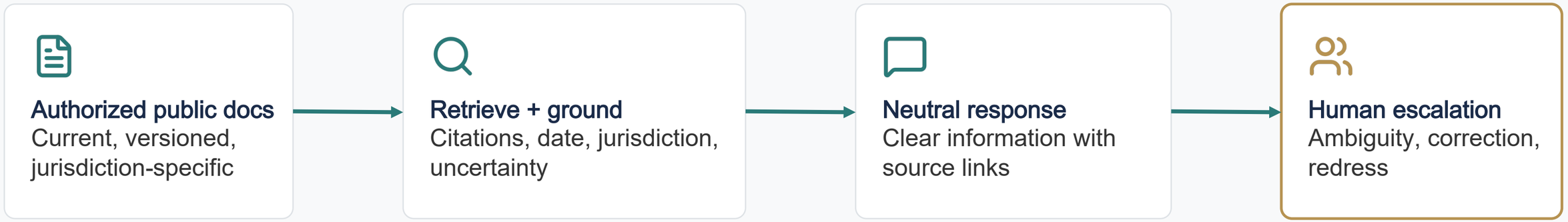
Potential benefits—access, efficiency, accuracy—remain partly untested; privacy, equal participation, security, and trust are governance constraints.

International IDEA (2024), Artificial Intelligence for Electoral Management

A neutral civic-information assistant

ILLUSTRATIVE HYPOTHETICAL PRODUCT

A "civic-information assistant" answers from authorized public documents. It is not a real company, voter profiler, or decision-maker.



Design boundaries accessibility or language preference may adapt presentation, not political or demographic profiling. No automated voter-decision rules. Uncertainty is surfaced rather than hidden.

OECD (2024), Reinforcing Democracy Initiative: digital democracy

EU governance separates risk from transparency

Current as checked 23 October 2026. The AI Act uses distinct transparency and high-risk pathways; this is not legal advice.

Application timeline

2 Aug 2026
Article 50 transparency applies

2 Dec 2026
Limited Article 50(2) marking transition ends for certain pre-existing providers

2 Dec 2027
Annex III high-risk obligations apply

Annex III, point 8(b): intended influence

High-risk classification concerns systems intended to influence an election, referendum, or voting behaviour.
The scope excludes outputs not directly exposed to natural persons, such as administrative or logistical campaign organisation tools.
Scope is not a ban on all political AI. Transparency marking is not truth verification.

The current Service Desk timeline reflects Digital Omnibus amendments.

EU AI Act Service Desk, implementation timeline | Annex III primary text

Political advertising: transparency and data limits

EU Regulation 2024/900 generally applies from **10 October 2025**. Its focus is accountability and rights, not how to target voters.

Transparency
Political-ad label
Sponsor identity
Related election or process
Targeting notice

Data limits
Directly collected from the data subject
Separate, explicit consent
No profiling using special-category political-opinion data

Boundary of the regulation
Editorial content and personal political opinions are not covered.
Compliance does not itself establish fairness or legitimacy.

Rights lens: informed public communication • data protection • traceable responsibility • meaningful accountability

EUR-Lex, transparency and targeting of political advertising: Regulation (EU) 2024/900

Procurement is a democratic risk decision

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A viable business case is necessary, not sufficient. Cost and accuracy do not settle public legitimacy, rights, or operational accountability.

Decision lens	Review criterion	Evidence or owner required
Purpose	Clearly defined public service problem	Bounded service rationale; named institutional owner
Data	Inputs, retention, and inferred attributes	Lawful basis, minimisation, protected-data boundary
Evidence	Validation in the intended context	Reliability, accessibility, and failure evidence
Audit + rights	Reviewable claims, changes, and impacts	Logs, independent review, correction and redress
Exit	Capacity to pause, replace, or withdraw	Contractual exit, continuity plan, accountable owners

Procurement therefore allocates risk, not merely software functionality.

United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights: privacy, expression, participation

Public-interest outcomes and metrics

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The evaluation target is equitable civic service and citizen agency—not vote persuasion, conversion, or political-opinion inference.

Outcome	Public-interest evidence	Rights / accountability signal
Accuracy	Traceable, current answer against an authorised source	Correction path and change record
Accessibility	Usability across language, format, and assistive needs	Barriers documented and addressed
Coverage	Comparable service across relevant jurisdictions and topics	Gaps visible rather than silently omitted
Privacy	Data minimisation; no protected political-data profiling	Consent is meaningful and revocable
Contestability	Human escalation, explanation, and appeal route	People can challenge a harmful outcome
Equitable service	Distributional review of failures and access	Agency is preserved for every citizen

Consent is a governance condition for protected data; it is not a licence to optimise political persuasion.

OECD (2024), digital democracy: integrity, fairness, accuracy, accountability, public trust

A deployment gate for civic AI

ILLUSTRATIVE PRODUCT REVIEW

Context: a content-only civic-information assistant using authorised public documents. No vendor case is implied.

Qualitative gate	Evidence needed before a decision
Factual reliability	Traceable sources, dated content, correction ownership
Accessibility	Usable formats and documented barriers across intended users
Privacy	No political-opinion inference; minimised data and clear retention
Escalation + logs	Staffed route, reviewable audit trail, incident handling
Redress + exit	Correction, withdrawal, and accountable institutional owner

GO—all gates evidenced; owners accept continuing review.

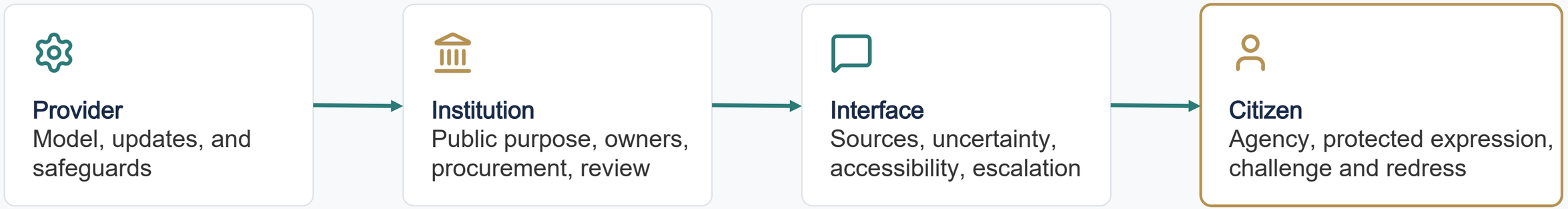
CONDITIONAL—bounded use only; remediation, review, and exit are named.

NO-GO—rights-relevant gaps, missing evidence, or unowned escalation remain.

United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights | International IDEA (2024)

Accountability after deployment

Accountability is distributed across the system. Areliable interface does not transfer civic responsibility away from institutions or citizens.



When something fails

Capture the incident • preserve reviewable logs • correct the record • communicate responsibility • offer redress • learn without chilling lawful expression.

United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights: Articles 12, 19, 21

AI can support politics without deciding for citizens

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1. Capability
Performance under stated conditions

→

2. Measured impact
Observed, bounded outcomes

→

3. Legitimacy
Protected agency, rights, and authority

Seven cases, seven bounded evidence lessons

Case	Bounded lesson
ICO / FTC	Consent and governance failure do not establish election causation.
FCC, New Hampshire	Initiated calls and legal authority are not turnout or vote effects.
Slovakia	Observed spread of fabricated audio leaves human impact unmeasured.
Salvi et al.	Immediate self-reported attitude is not a voting endpoint.
Habermas Machine	Statement preference is not democratic legitimacy.
vTaiwan / Polis	Opinion mapping is not a representative mandate.
OpenAI report	Service disruption is not prevalence or public-impact measurement.

Case sources: ICO; FTC; FCC; Harvard Misinformation Review; Salvi et al.; Tessler et al.; Small et al.; OpenAI (linked on next slide).

Case evidence and original research

Short bibliography; follow the source link for the full record, method, and qualification.

ICO (2018) — political data analytics investigation
Primary report
FTC (2019) — Cambridge Analytica order
Agency release
FCC (2024) — New Hampshire robocall final order
Final order
Harvard Misinformation Review (2024) — Slovak case
Bounded case analysis

Salvi et al. (2025) — GPT-4 debate RCT
Nature Human Behaviour
Salvi et al. (2026) — correction
Direct-comparison correction
Tessler et al. (2024) — Habermas Machine
Science article
Small et al. (2021) — Polis / vTaiwan
Technical paper
OpenAI (May 2024) — covert influence report
Vendor transparency report

Primary and original research sources used throughout this lecture; links are clickable.

Governance and teaching media sources

Official and primary sources used for the rights, governance, and media framing of this lecture.

United Nations—Universal Declaration of Human Rights
Primary text
OECD (2024)—digital democracy and institutions
Reinforcing Democracy Initiative
International IDEA (2024)—electoral management
AI for Electoral Management
EU AI Act Service Desk—current implementation timeline
Timeline reflecting Digital Omnibus amendments
EU AI Act, Annex III—high-risk scope
Point 8(b) primary scope text

EU Regulation 2024/900—political advertising
Transparency and targeting summary
C2PA 2.4—provenance and validation
Content Credentials explainer
WIRED / WITNESS (2019)—expert perspective
Original WIRED film
BBC Click (2019)—Polis context
Original BBC Click film

EU dates on the preceding governance slides are current as checked 23 October 2026.